

The Cask of Amontillado

Edgar Allan Poe · 1846

First published: Godey's Lady's Book, Nov 1846

TEACHER EDITION · CURRICULUM UNIT

AP edition (standards shown for this framework only)

One 90-minute lesson (the whole story), with an optional take-home essay

Syllabus · 90-minute lesson plans · lecture scripts · vocabulary · quizzes with keys · writing prompts at eleven rigor levels · SAT-style items · whole-book test · essays

Liber et Libri · Lux et Libri LLC

Cover: John Constable, The Hay Wain (1821). Public domain (Wikimedia Commons).

Contents and unit overview

1. Unit overview and the 90-minute lesson
2. Syllabus (weekly pacing)
3. Lesson 1: introduction (author, context, reception, overview)
4. Lesson plans and lecture scripts (chapters 1–1), each with vocabulary, discussion questions, annotation focus, quiz and key, writing prompts and SAT-style items
5. Whole-book test and answer key
6. Essay assignments at eleven rigor levels

Edition: Reading text: https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/The_Works_of_the_Late_Edgar_Allan_Poe_(1850)/Volume_1/The_Cask_of_Amontillado (revision 14833566), cleaned for Liber et Libri.

Grades: Grades 8–12 (scales to graduate via rigor levels). Short story: read whole in one 90-minute lesson (assign longer stories as pre-reading). Middle School prompts use the full text when the grade tags include 6–8; otherwise teacher-selected passages. **Weeks:** 1. **Class days:** 2 × 90 minutes (1 chapter lessons plus seminar, test and essay days).

Essential questions

- What does The Cask of Amontillado suggest about revenge and pride?
- What does The Cask of Amontillado suggest about deception?
- What does The Cask of Amontillado suggest about the burden of the past?

Objectives

- Cite textual evidence to support analysis of what the text says explicitly and implicitly.
- Determine themes and analyze their development over the course of the story.
- Analyze how characters, setting and point of view interact.
- Determine the meaning of words and phrases as they are used in the text.
- Write arguments to support claims with clear reasons and relevant evidence.

Standards: AP

AP-LIT.CHR, AP-LIT.SET, AP-LIT.STR, AP-LIT.NAR, AP-LIT.FIG, AP-LIT.LAN

AP English Literature and Composition big ideas (our summaries; apcentral.collegeboard.org)

Assessments: Daily story quizzes (auto-graded); Weekly writing prompt (rubric); Socratic seminars (scheduled days); Whole-story test (scheduled day); Final essay (scheduled day); College Sophomore and above write one essay of the five

Differentiation: Every prompt and quiz has eleven rigor levels (Middle School through Graduate / PhD); the

app applies student override, then class standard, then the automatic level. Each prompt is tagged for Common Core, Indiana 2023, Dual Credit (Indiana College Core), AP and Cambridge where they apply.
Materials: Liber et Libri reader; Annotation journal; Story lecture slides or script

The 90-minute lesson

#	Segment	Mode	Minutes	Clock
1	Bell-ringer	You do	8	0–8
2	Vocabulary with etymology notes	I do	10	8–18
3	Background and context	I do	10	18–28
4	I do: modeled close reading	I do	12	28–40
5	We do: guided annotation	We do	15	40–55
6	You do: independent annotation	You do	15	55–70
7	Discussion	We do	10	70–80
8	Exit ticket / chapter quiz	You do	7	80–87
9	Closure	I do	3	87–90
	Total		**90**	

Syllabus

Week	Chapters	Lessons	Focus and activities	Assessment
1	*Introduction: author, context and reception* The Cask of Amontillado	2 × 90 min (180 min)	*revenge and pride* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Story quizzes in the app • Introduction: author, context and reception • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt

Lesson plans and lecture scripts

Each chapter is one 90-minute class. Scripts are a starting point; adapt them to your students. Teacher summaries contain spoilers.

Lesson 1: Introduction to The Cask of Amontillado

Author biography

Edgar Allan Poe was born in Boston on 19 January 1809 to touring actors; orphaned before he was three, he was raised in Richmond, Virginia, by the merchant John Allan, with whom he later quarrelled bitterly. He attended the University of Virginia, served in the U.S. Army and was dismissed from West Point, then lived by his pen as a poet, critic and magazine editor (the Southern Literary Messenger, Graham's Magazine) in Richmond, Philadelphia and New York. He married his young cousin Virginia Clemm, who died of tuberculosis in 1847. "The Raven" (1845) made him famous but never prosperous. He is credited with inventing the modern detective story ("The Murders in the Rue Morgue," 1841) and argued that a short story should create a single "unity of effect." He died in Baltimore on 7 October 1849; the cause of his death is unknown.

Historical and cultural context

The story is set during carnival in an unnamed Italian city, among aristocrats with family crests and wine cellars that double as catacombs. Poe wrote it in 1846 in the middle of a bitter literary feud with the writers Thomas Dunn English and Hiram Fuller; some scholars read Montresor's revenge as Poe's fantasy of answering his critics.

Publication and reception, then and now

First published in Godey's Lady's Book, one of the most popular American magazines, in November 1846.

Then: It received little critical comment at the time; Godey's readers knew Poe mainly as a critic and poet.

Now: It is a classic of revenge fiction and dramatic irony, widely taught in middle and high school, and much debated: why does Montresor tell the story fifty years later, and to whom?

Overview (spoiler-free)

Montresor, insulted by Fortunato, vows revenge. During carnival he lures Fortunato, a proud wine expert, into his family's vaults with the promise of a rare cask of Amontillado sherry.

Main themes

- revenge and pride: Montresor's need for revenge and Fortunato's pride in his palate both drive the plot.
- deception: almost everything Montresor says to Fortunato means something else.
- the burden of the past: the story is told half a century later; is it a boast or a confession?

Why it matters

The story is a model of dramatic irony and of a narrator who manipulates both his victim and the reader; it also raises lasting questions about revenge and justice.

Spoilers · teacher only

Montresor chains the drunken Fortunato in a niche and walls him in alive; fifty years later, he says, no one has disturbed the bones.

Lesson plan (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)

Before we open The Cask of Amontillado: Is revenge ever justified? What would make it "fair"?
Prompt: Before we open The Cask of Amontillado: Is revenge ever justified? What would make it "fair"?

8–18 min · Key terms · I do (10 min)

dramatic irony; verbal irony; first-person narrator; carnival; Amontillado (a Spanish sherry); catacombs.

18–28 min · Mini-lecture: author, context, reception · I do (10 min)

About the author. Edgar Allan Poe was born in Boston on 19 January 1809 to touring actors; orphaned before he was three, he was raised in Richmond, Virginia, by the merchant John Allan, with whom he later quarrelled bitterly. He attended the University of Virginia, served in the U.S. Army and was dismissed from West Point, then lived by his pen as a poet, critic and magazine editor (the Southern Literary Messenger, Graham's Magazine) in Richmond, Philadelphia and New York. He married his young cousin Virginia Clemm, who died of tuberculosis in 1847. "The Raven" (1845) made him famous but never prosperous. He is credited with inventing the modern detective story ("The Murders in the Rue Morgue," 1841) and argued that a short story should create a single "unity of effect." He died in Baltimore on 7 October 1849; the cause of his death is unknown. The world of the book. The story is set during carnival in an unnamed Italian city, among aristocrats with family crests and wine cellars that double as catacombs. Poe wrote it in 1846 in the middle of a bitter literary feud with the writers Thomas Dunn English and Hiram Fuller; some scholars read Montresor's revenge as Poe's fantasy of answering his critics. Publication and reception. First published in Godey's Lady's Book, one of the most popular American magazines, in November 1846. Then: It received little critical comment at the time; Godey's readers knew Poe mainly as a critic and poet. Now: It is a classic of revenge fiction and dramatic irony, widely taught in middle and high school, and much debated: why does Montresor tell the story fifty years later, and to whom?

28–40 min · I do: the book in one passage · I do (12 min)

“The thousand injuries of Fortunato I had borne as I best could; but when he ventured upon insult, I vowed revenge” (The Cask of Amontillado, paragraph 1). The opening: we never learn what the insult was.

> *The thousand injuries of Fortunato I had borne as I best could; but when he ventured upon insult, I vowed revenge (The Cask of Amontillado, paragraph 1)*

Think-aloud: “The thousand injuries of Fortunato I had borne as I best could; but when he ventured upon insult, I vowed revenge” (The Cask of Amontillado, paragraph 1). The opening: we never learn what the insult was.

40–55 min · We do: overview and themes · We do (15 min)

What the book is about (no spoilers): Montresor, insulted by Fortunato, vows revenge. During carnival he lures Fortunato, a proud wine expert, into his family's vaults with the promise of a rare cask of Amontillado sherry. Themes to track: revenge and pride: Montresor's need for revenge and Fortunato's pride in his palate both drive the plot. deception: almost everything Montresor says to Fortunato means something else. the burden of the past: the story is told half a century later; is it a boast or a confession?

55–70 min · You do: reading journal · You do (15 min)

Set up a reading journal: one page per theme with a prediction and a question.
Task: Set up a reading journal for The Cask of Amontillado: one page per theme, each with a prediction and a question.

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)

Why does The Cask of Amontillado still matter? The story is a model of dramatic irony and of a narrator who manipulates both his victim and the reader; it also raises lasting questions about revenge and justice.
Anchor question: Why might The Cask of Amontillado still be taught today?
Facilitation: The story is a model of dramatic irony and of a narrator who manipulates both his victim and the reader; it also raises lasting questions about revenge and justice.

80–87 min · Exit ticket · You do (7 min)

Why might Poe never tell us what Fortunato's insult was? Answer: It keeps us inside Montresor's head and makes us question whether any insult could justify the punishment; the omission makes him less trustworthy.
Exit ticket: Why might Poe never tell us what Fortunato's insult was?
Answer: It keeps us inside Montresor's head and makes us question whether any insult could justify the punishment; the omission makes him less trustworthy.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)

Tomorrow we begin reading: The Cask of Amontillado.

Teacher notes · sources: Poe Museum, Richmond, "Poe's Life" (https://poemuseum.org/poes-life/); Edgar Allan Poe Society of Baltimore (texts and publication history) (https://www.eapoe.org/); Poe Society of Baltimore, "The Cask of Amontillado" (https://www.eapoe.org/works/tales/caska.htm)

Flags (verify before teaching):

- The link to Poe's feud with English and Fuller is a scholarly interpretation, not a documented intention.

Lesson 2: The Cask of Amontillado

Focus: revenge carried out with perfect control

Content note (a man is walled up alive): Sensitive content: A man is walled up alive. Preview the story, tell students in advance, and allow a pass on reading aloud. Keep discussion on how the writer uses these elements, not on graphic detail.
Student preview: Heads-up: this story includes a man is walled up alive.
Suggested language: "Why does the writer include this, and what does it make us notice?"

Teacher only · spoilers

Montresor, vowing revenge for 'a thousand injuries' and an insult from Fortunato, lures the drunken wine connoisseur during carnival into his family catacombs with the promise of a rare cask of Amontillado. Deep in the vaults he chains Fortunato into a niche and walls him in alive. He tells the story fifty years later; no one has disturbed the bones.

Background: The story (1846) is set during carnival in an unnamed Italian city. Its catacombs echo Roman and Parisian ossuaries. Amontillado is a Spanish sherry.

Significance: It is a model of dramatic and verbal irony, from Fortunato's name ('fortunate') to the toast 'to your long life'. It is a Common Core Appendix B exemplar for grades 11–CCR.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Have you ever felt someone deserved to be paid back? What is the difference between justice and revenge? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to revenge and pride because.... Content note before we start: Heads-up: this story includes a man is walled up alive.
Prompt: Have you ever felt someone deserved to be paid back? What is the difference between justice and revenge?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to revenge and pride because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: Montresor's rules for revenge ("I must not only punish but punish with impunity") show a man who has thought this through for a long time.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: trickle — to flow in drops; requesting — express the need or desire for; ask for; materially — with respect to material aspects; explicit — precisely and clearly expressed or readily observable; leaving nothing to implication; luckily — by good fortune.
Words: trickle: to flow in drops · requesting: express the need or desire for; ask for · materially: with respect to material aspects · explicit: precisely and clearly expressed or readily observable; leaving nothing to implication · luckily: by good fortune

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
The story (1846) is set during carnival in an unnamed Italian city. Its catacombs echo Roman and Parisian ossuaries. Amontillado is a Spanish sherry. It is a model of dramatic and verbal irony, from Fortunato's name ('fortunate') to the toast 'to your long life'. It is a Common Core Appendix B exemplar for grades 11–CCR. Irony: Dramatic irony saturates the dialogue: Fortunato says he will not die of a cough, and Montresor answers "True—true"; Fortunato makes the Masonic sign and Montresor shows a trowel. Setting: The descent from carnival into damp catacombs lined with bones moves from life to death; the nitre on the walls is both a pretext and an image of the grave. Characterization: Montresor is cold, patient and articulate; Fortunato's pride ("you are a fool") and drunkenness make him easy to lead. Watch for the family crest: a foot crushing a serpent whose fangs are in the heel, with the motto "Nemo me impune lacessit" (No one attacks me with impunity): revenge as inherited identity.

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. "I must not only punish, but punish with impunity" (The Cask of Amontillado, paragraph 1). His philosophy of revenge. That is irony at work: Dramatic irony saturates the dialogue: Fortunato says he will not die of a cough, and Montresor answers "True—true"; Fortunato makes the Masonic sign and Montresor shows a trowel.

> *I must not only punish, but punish with impunity* *(The Cask of Amontillado, paragraph 1)*

Think-aloud: I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. "I must not only punish, but punish with impunity" (The Cask of Amontillado, paragraph 1). His philosophy of revenge. That is irony at work: Dramatic irony saturates the dialogue: Fortunato says he will not die of a cough, and Montresor answers "True—true"; Fortunato makes the Masonic sign and Montresor shows a trowel.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: The toast is ironic because Fortunato will soon be one of the buried; "long life" means the opposite. Expected link: deception and dramatic irony. Ask: How does this line connect to revenge and pride? Expected: Montresor's rules for revenge ("I must not only punish but punish with impunity") show a man who has thought this through for a long time. (Fortunato's toast; the reply "And I to your long life" is pure irony.)

> *I drink," he said, "to the buried that repose around us (The Cask of Amontillado, paragraph 41)*

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: The toast is ironic because Fortunato will soon be one of the buried; "long life" means the opposite. Expected link: deception and dramatic irony.
Ask: How does this line connect to revenge and pride?
Expected answer: Montresor's rules for revenge ("I must not only punish but punish with impunity") show a man who has thought this through for a long time. (Fortunato's toast; the reply "And I to your long life" is pure irony.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the story for irony, setting (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about revenge carried out with perfect control? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how The Cask of Amontillado develops the idea of revenge carried out with perfect control. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of irony and setting shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: Montresor's revenge depends on irony: he tells Fortunato the truth in words that Fortunato cannot understand. When the text says "I drink," he said, "to the buried that repose around us" (The Cask of Amontillado, paragraph 41), it shows this directly. When Fortunato toasts "the buried that repose around us," Montresor replies "And I to your long life," knowing he is about to bury him; the reader hears the double meaning Fortunato misses.
Task: Annotate the story for irony, setting (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about revenge carried out with perfect control? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how The Cask of Amontillado develops the idea of revenge carried out with perfect control. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of irony and setting shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: Montresor's revenge depends on irony: he tells Fortunato the truth in words that Fortunato cannot understand. When the text says "I drink," he said, "to the buried that repose around us" (The Cask of Amontillado, paragraph 41), it shows this directly. When Fortunato toasts "the buried that repose around us," Montresor replies "And I to your long life," knowing he is about to bury him; the reader hears the double meaning Fortunato misses.

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: Have you ever felt someone deserved to be paid back? What is the difference between justice and revenge? Ask: why does Montresor tell the story fifty years later? Is "My heart grew sick" guilt or the damp?
Anchor question: Have you ever felt someone deserved to be paid back? What is the difference between justice and revenge?
Facilitation: Ask: why does Montresor tell the story fifty years later? Is "My heart grew sick" guilt or the damp?

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Story quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Story quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about revenge carried out with perfect control? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: Montresor's revenge depends on irony: he tells Fortunato the truth in words that Fortunato cannot understand. (“I drink," he said, "to the buried that repose around us”, The Cask of Amontillado, paragraph 41). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about revenge carried out with perfect control? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: Montresor's revenge depends on irony: he tells Fortunato the truth in words that Fortunato cannot understand. (“I drink," he said, "to the buried that repose around us”, The Cask of Amontillado, paragraph 41). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how irony shapes revenge carried out with perfect control. Key takeaway: Montresor's rules for revenge ("I must not only punish but punish with impunity") show a man who has thought this through for a long time.

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Irony:** Dramatic irony saturates the dialogue: Fortunato says he will not die of a cough, and Montresor answers "True—true"; Fortunato makes the Masonic sign and Montresor shows a trowel.
- **Setting:** The descent from carnival into damp catacombs lined with bones moves from life to death; the nitre on the walls is both a pretext and an image of the grave.
- **Characterization:** Montresor is cold, patient and articulate; Fortunato's pride ("you are a fool") and drunkenness make him easy to lead.

Themes and how they develop

- **revenge and pride:** Montresor's rules for revenge ("I must not only punish but punish with impunity") show a man who has thought this through for a long time.

Symbols and motifs

- **the family crest:** a foot crushing a serpent whose fangs are in the heel, with the motto "Nemo me impune lacessit" (No one attacks me with impunity): revenge as inherited identity.

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- "I must not only punish, but punish with impunity" (The Cask of Amontillado, paragraph 1) His philosophy of revenge.
- "I drink," he said, "to the buried that repose around us" (The Cask of Amontillado, paragraph 41) Fortunato's toast; the reply "And I to your long life" is pure irony.
- "For the love of God, Montresor" (The Cask of Amontillado, paragraph 83) Fortunato's last plea; Montresor echoes it mockingly.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: Montresor's revenge depends on irony: he tells Fortunato the truth in words that Fortunato cannot understand.
Evidence: "I drink," he said, "to the buried that repose around us" (The Cask of Amontillado, paragraph 41)
Reasoning: When Fortunato toasts "the buried that repose around us," Montresor replies "And I to your long life," knowing he is about to bury him; the reader hears the double meaning Fortunato misses.

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
trickle (verb)	to flow in drops	*The drops of moisture trickle among the bones.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
requesting (verb)	express the need or desire for; ask for	*I passed down a long and winding staircase, requesting him to be cautious as he followed.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
materially (adverb)	with respect to material aspects	*In this respect I did not differ from him materially: I was skilful in the Italian vintages myself, and bought largely whenever I could.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
explicit (adjective)	precisely and clearly expressed or readily observable; leaving nothing to implication	*I had told them that I should not return until the morning, and had given them explicit orders not to stir from the house.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
luckily (adverb)	by good fortune	*I said to him—"My dear Fortunato, you are luckily met.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
accosted (verb)	approached and spoken to	*He accosted me with excessive warmth, for he had been drinking much.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

impunity (noun)	exemption from punishment or loss	*I must not only punish, but punish with impunity.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
subsided (verb)	wear off or die down	*When at last the clanking subsided, I resumed the trowel, and finished without interruption the fifth, the sixth, and the seventh tier.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
increases (verb)	grows	*"The nitre!" I said; "see, it increases.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
depended (verb)	be contingent upon (something that is elided)	*From one of these depended a short chain, from the other a padlock.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

Discussion questions

1. Have you ever felt someone deserved to be paid back? What is the difference between justice and revenge?
2. Where does irony appear in this story, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this story connect to the book's larger concern with revenge and pride?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Middle School: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. What reason does Montresor give for his revenge? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · AP-LIT.STR] Look for: A thousand injuries and then an insult
2. How does Montresor lure Fortunato into the vaults? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · AP-LIT.STR] Look for: With the promise of a rare cask of Amontillado
3. What is Fortunato wearing? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · AP-LIT.NAR] Look for: A jester's motley costume with a cap and bells
4. What is Montresor's family motto about? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · AP-LIT.FIG] Look for: No one attacks me with impunity
5. How long ago did the events take place, as Montresor tells it? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · AP-LIT.NAR] Look for: Fifty years
6. Retell the three most important events of “The Cask of Amontillado” in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · AP-LIT.STR] Look for: Montresor, vowing revenge for 'a thousand injuries' and an insult from Fortunato, lures the drunken wine connoisseur during carnival into his family catacombs with the promise of a rare cask of

Amontillado. Deep in the vaults he chains Fortunato into a niche and walls him in alive. He tells the story fifty years later; no one has disturbed the bones.

7. Which characters appear or are mentioned in “The Cask of Amontillado”? Name two and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · AP-LIT.CHR] Look for: Names and actions taken from the story; check against the teacher summary.
8. Where and when does “The Cask of Amontillado” take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · AP-LIT.SET] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the story.
9. Reread: “The drops of moisture trickle among the bones.” What does “trickle” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · AP-LIT.FIG] Look for: trickle: to flow in drops.
10. Reread: “I passed down a long and winding staircase, requesting him to be cautious as he followed.” What does “requesting” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · AP-LIT.FIG] Look for: requesting: express the need or desire for; ask for.

Inferential / analytical

1. What does “The Cask of Amontillado” suggest about revenge carried out with perfect control? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: It is a model of dramatic and verbal irony, from Fortunato's name ('fortunate') to the toast 'to your long life'. It is a Common Core Appendix B exemplar for grades 11–CCR.
2. Find one example of irony in this story. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · AP-LIT.NAR] Look for: Look for gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true.
3. How does the setting in this story shape what we understand about revenge carried out with perfect control? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.SET] Look for: Look for where and when events happen and how place shapes action or feeling.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Montresor's revenge depends on irony: he tells Fortunato the truth in words that Fortunato cannot understand. Useful evidence: “I must not only punish, but punish with impunity” (The Cask of Amontillado, paragraph 1): His philosophy of revenge. On setting: The descent from carnival into damp catacombs lined with bones moves from life to death; the nitre on the walls is both a pretext and an image of the grave. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. In the passage that begins “The thousand injuries of Fortunato I had borne as I best could; but when he ventured upon insult, I vowed revenge.”, why might Poe have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · AP-LIT.FIG] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
5. What causes the main turn in “The Cask of Amontillado”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · AP-LIT.STR] Look for: Montresor, vowing revenge for 'a thousand injuries' and an insult from Fortunato, lures the drunken wine connoisseur during carnival into his family catacombs with the promise of a rare cask of Amontillado. Deep in the vaults he chains Fortunato into a niche and walls him in alive. He tells the…
6. As the opening story, what does “The Cask of Amontillado” set up that the rest of The Cask of Amontillado will need? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.STR] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous story.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Montresor's revenge depends on irony: he tells Fortunato the truth in words that Fortunato cannot understand. Useful evidence: “I drink," he said, "to the buried that repose around us” (The Cask of Amontillado, paragraph 41): Fortunato's toast; the reply "And I

to your long life" is pure irony. Theme link: Montresor's rules for revenge ("I must not only punish but punish with impunity") show a man who has thought this through for a long time. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

7. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say and do here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.CHR] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Montresor's revenge depends on irony: he tells Fortunato the truth in words that Fortunato cannot understand. Useful evidence: “For the love of God, Montresor” (The Cask of Amontillado, paragraph 83): Fortunato's last plea; Montresor echoes it mockingly. On characterization: Montresor is cold, patient and articulate; Fortunato's pride ("you are a fool") and drunkenness make him easy to lead. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. The bell-ringer asked: “Have you ever felt someone deserved to be paid back? What is the difference between justice and revenge?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
9. Where does characterization appear, and how does it connect this story to the larger concern with revenge and pride? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.CHR] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Montresor's revenge depends on irony: he tells Fortunato the truth in words that Fortunato cannot understand. Useful evidence: “I must not only punish, but punish with impunity” (The Cask of Amontillado, paragraph 1): His philosophy of revenge. On characterization: Montresor is cold, patient and articulate; Fortunato's pride ("you are a fool") and drunkenness make him easy to lead. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
10. Background: The story (1846) is set during carnival in an unnamed Italian city. Its catacombs echo Roman and Parisian ossuaries. Amontillado is a Spanish sherry. How does knowing this change the way you read one moment in the story? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.SET] Look for: A specific moment reread in light of the context.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Montresor's revenge depends on irony: he tells Fortunato the truth in words that Fortunato cannot understand. Useful evidence: “I drink," he said, "to the buried that repose around us” (The Cask of Amontillado, paragraph 41): Fortunato's toast; the reply "And I to your long life" is pure irony. On setting: The descent from carnival into damp catacombs lined with bones moves from life to death; the nitre on the walls is both a pretext and an image of the grave. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. A critic might argue: “It is a model of dramatic and verbal irony, from Fortunato's name ('fortunate') to the toast 'to your long life'. It is a Common Core Appendix B exemplar for grades 11–CCR.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the story. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.LAN, AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Montresor's revenge depends on irony: he tells Fortunato the truth in words that Fortunato cannot understand. Useful evidence: “For the love of God,

Montresor" (The Cask of Amontillado, paragraph 83): Fortunato's last plea; Montresor echoes it mockingly. Theme link: Montresor's rules for revenge ("I must not only punish but punish with impunity") show a man who has thought this through for a long time. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

2. Which character in this story acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.CHR, AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Montresor's revenge depends on irony: he tells Fortunato the truth in words that Fortunato cannot understand. Useful evidence: "I must not only punish, but punish with impunity" (The Cask of Amontillado, paragraph 1): His philosophy of revenge. On characterization: Montresor is cold, patient and articulate; Fortunato's pride ("you are a fool") and drunkenness make him easy to lead. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
3. Rewrite one moment of "The Cask of Amontillado" from the point of view of a different character. What does the new angle reveal or hide about revenge carried out with perfect control? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.NAR, AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Montresor's revenge depends on irony: he tells Fortunato the truth in words that Fortunato cannot understand. Useful evidence: "I drink," he said, "to the buried that repose around us" (The Cask of Amontillado, paragraph 41): Fortunato's toast; the reply "And I to your long life" is pure irony. Theme link: Montresor's rules for revenge ("I must not only punish but punish with impunity") show a man who has thought this through for a long time. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. Write three questions of your own about "The Cask of Amontillado": one recall, one "why/how", and one "should/what if". Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.LAN, AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Montresor's revenge depends on irony: he tells Fortunato the truth in words that Fortunato cannot understand. Useful evidence: "For the love of God, Montresor" (The Cask of Amontillado, paragraph 83): Fortunato's last plea; Montresor echoes it mockingly. Theme link: Montresor's rules for revenge ("I must not only punish but punish with impunity") show a man who has thought this through for a long time. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. Connect this story to deception: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Poe need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.LAN, AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Montresor's revenge depends on irony: he tells Fortunato the truth in words that Fortunato cannot understand. Useful evidence: "I must not only punish, but punish with impunity" (The Cask of Amontillado, paragraph 1): His philosophy of revenge. Theme link: Montresor's rules for revenge ("I must not only punish but punish with impunity") show a man who has thought this through for a long time. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
6. Is the irony in this story effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.NAR, AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Montresor's revenge depends on irony: he tells Fortunato the truth in words that Fortunato cannot understand. Useful evidence: "I drink," he said, "to the

buried that repose around us” (The Cask of Amontillado, paragraph 41): Fortunato's toast; the reply "And I to your long life" is pure irony. On irony: Dramatic irony saturates the dialogue: Fortunato says he will not die of a cough, and Montresor answers "True—true"; Fortunato makes the Masonic sign and Montresor shows a trowel. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

7. Compare how “The Cask of Amontillado” treats revenge carried out with perfect control with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does The Cask of Amontillado see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.LAN, AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Montresor's revenge depends on irony: he tells Fortunato the truth in words that Fortunato cannot understand. Useful evidence: “For the love of God, Montresor” (The Cask of Amontillado, paragraph 83): Fortunato's last plea; Montresor echoes it mockingly. Theme link: Montresor's rules for revenge ("I must not only punish but punish with impunity") show a man who has thought this through for a long time. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. As the final story, does this ending resolve revenge and pride? Argue whether the ending is earned. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.STR, AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Montresor's revenge depends on irony: he tells Fortunato the truth in words that Fortunato cannot understand. Useful evidence: “I must not only punish, but punish with impunity” (The Cask of Amontillado, paragraph 1): His philosophy of revenge. Theme link: Montresor's rules for revenge ("I must not only punish but punish with impunity") show a man who has thought this through for a long time. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this story (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about revenge carried out with perfect control? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.LAN, AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Montresor's revenge depends on irony: he tells Fortunato the truth in words that Fortunato cannot understand. Useful evidence: “I drink," he said, "to the buried that repose around us” (The Cask of Amontillado, paragraph 41): Fortunato's toast; the reply "And I to your long life" is pure irony. Theme link: Montresor's rules for revenge ("I must not only punish but punish with impunity") show a man who has thought this through for a long time. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
10. What question would you most like to ask Edgar Allan Poe about this story, and what answer do you think the text itself gives? [DOK 4 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.LAN, AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: A student-generated question answered from evidence.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Montresor's revenge depends on irony: he tells Fortunato the truth in words that Fortunato cannot understand. Useful evidence: “For the love of God, Montresor” (The Cask of Amontillado, paragraph 83): Fortunato's last plea; Montresor echoes it mockingly. Theme link: Montresor's rules for revenge ("I must not only punish but punish with impunity") show a man who has thought this through for a long time. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Irony:** look for gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Setting**: where and when events happen and how place shapes action or feeling
- Also notice **Characterization**: what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them

Chapter quiz

1. What reason does Montresor give for his revenge?
   A. A thousand injuries and then an insult
   B. A stolen inheritance
   C. A broken engagement
   D. A lost duel
2. How does Montresor lure Fortunato into the vaults?
   A. With a map to buried gold
   B. By challenging him to a duel
   C. By asking for medical help
   D. With the promise of a rare cask of Amontillado
3. What is Fortunato wearing?
   A. A jester's motley costume with a cap and bells
   B. A soldier's uniform
   C. A priest's robe
   D. A black mask and cloak
4. What is Montresor's family motto about?
   A. Mercy is strength
   B. Faith above all
   C. No one attacks me with impunity
   D. Wine reveals truth
5. How long ago did the events take place, as Montresor tells it?
   A. One week
   B. Ten years
   C. A century
   D. Fifty years
6. In the line “The drops of moisture trickle among the bones.”, what does “trickle” most nearly mean?
   A. express the need or desire for; ask for
   B. to flow in drops
   C. precisely and clearly expressed or readily observable; leaving nothing to implication
   D. with respect to material aspects

7. In the line “I passed down a long and winding staircase, requesting him to be cautious as he followed.”, what does “requesting” most nearly mean?
   A. precisely and clearly expressed or readily observable; leaving nothing to implication
   B. to flow in drops
   C. express the need or desire for; ask for
   D. with respect to material aspects

Answer key: 1. A (A thousand injuries and then an insult); 2. D (With the promise of a rare cask of Amontillado); 3. A (A jester's motley costume with a cap and bells); 4. C (No one attacks me with impunity); 5. D (Fifty years); 6. B (to flow in drops); 7. C (express the need or desire for; ask for)

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Middle School (250 words; AP: see unit standards): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track; this story is above the grades 6–8 complexity band, so work from the passage your teacher selects). In “The Cask of Amontillado,” how does Poe show revenge carried out with perfect control? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the irony you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; AP: see unit standards): In The Cask of Amontillado, how does Poe develop the idea of revenge carried out with perfect control? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the irony in the story helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; AP: see unit standards): Analyze how The Cask of Amontillado develops the idea of revenge carried out with perfect control. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of irony and setting shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; AP: see unit standards): Analyze how the structure of The Cask of Amontillado (where it begins, turns and ends) and its irony shape the reader's understanding of revenge carried out with perfect control. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning. Distinguish what is directly stated from what is really meant.

HS Senior (600 words; AP: see unit standards): Two readers disagree about what The Cask of Amontillado suggests about revenge carried out with perfect control. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the story's irony and setting), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay. Distinguish what is directly stated from what is really meant.

AP (650 words; AP: AP-LIT.NAR, AP-LIT.LAN): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how Edgar Allan Poe uses irony in The Cask of Amontillado to complicate the reader's understanding of revenge carried out with perfect control. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; AP: see unit standards): Situate The Cask of Amontillado within its historical and literary context and argue how the story's treatment of revenge carried out with perfect control responds

to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; AP: see unit standards): Read The Cask of Amontillado alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the story's handling of revenge carried out with perfect control follows or bends those conventions, using the irony as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; AP: see unit standards): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to The Cask of Amontillado and its treatment of revenge carried out with perfect control. State your method, show what it reveals in the story's irony and setting, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; AP: see unit standards): Develop a research argument that reads The Cask of Amontillado as evidence for a larger claim about revenge carried out with perfect control in The Cask of Amontillado. Connect close reading of the story to the whole story, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; AP: see unit standards): Develop an original argument that reads The Cask of Amontillado as a hinge in the story's larger treatment of revenge carried out with perfect control. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on The Cask of Amontillado.

SAT-style questions

1. *In this respect I did not differ from him materially: I was skilful in the Italian vintages myself, and bought largely whenever I could.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “materially” most nearly mean?

   A. wear off or die down

   B. with respect to material aspects

   C. be contingent upon (something that is elided)

   D. grows

2. *The thousand injuries of Fortunato I had borne as I best could; but when he ventured upon insult, I vowed revenge. You, who so well know the nature of my soul, will not suppose, however, that I gave utterance to a threat. At length I would be avenged; this was a point definitively settled—but the very definitiveness with which it was resolved, precluded the idea of risk. I must not only punish, but punish with impunity. A wrong is unredressed when retribution overtakes its redresser. It is equally unredressed when the avenger fails to make himself felt as such to him who has done the wrong.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of “The Cask of Amontillado”?

   A. The loss of faith in human goodness

   B. A girl's first encounter with death across the class line

   C. A crime that backfires

   D. Revenge carried out with perfect control

SAT key: 1. B (with respect to material aspects); 2. D (Revenge carried out with perfect control)

Whole-book test

The Cask of Amontillado: whole-book test · 90 minutes

Part I: Multiple choice

1. What reason does Montresor give for his revenge?
   A. A thousand injuries and then an insult
   B. A stolen inheritance
   C. A broken engagement
   D. A lost duel
2. How does Montresor lure Fortunato into the vaults?
   A. With a map to buried gold
   B. By challenging him to a duel
   C. By asking for medical help
   D. With the promise of a rare cask of Amontillado
3. What is Fortunato wearing?
   A. A jester's motley costume with a cap and bells
   B. A soldier's uniform
   C. A priest's robe
   D. A black mask and cloak
4. What is Montresor's family motto about?
   A. Mercy is strength
   B. Faith above all
   C. No one attacks me with impunity
   D. Wine reveals truth
5. How long ago did the events take place, as Montresor tells it?
   A. One week
   B. Ten years
   C. A century
   D. Fifty years
6. In the line “The drops of moisture trickle among the bones.”, what does “trickle” most nearly mean?
   A. express the need or desire for; ask for
   B. to flow in drops
   C. precisely and clearly expressed or readily observable; leaving nothing to implication
   D. with respect to material aspects

7. In the line “I passed down a long and winding staircase, requesting him to be cautious as he followed.”, what does “requesting” most nearly mean?
   A. precisely and clearly expressed or readily observable; leaving nothing to implication
   B. to flow in drops
   C. express the need or desire for; ask for
   D. with respect to material aspects
8. As used in the story (“The drops of moisture trickle among the bones.”), what does “trickle” mean?
   A. to flow in drops
   B. by good fortune
   C. wear off or die down
   D. express the need or desire for; ask for
9. As used in the story (“I passed down a long and winding staircase, requesting him to be cautious as he followed.”), what does “requesting” mean?
   A. approached and spoken to
   B. express the need or desire for; ask for
   C. grows
   D. with respect to material aspects
10. As used in the story (“In this respect I did not differ from him materially: I was skilful in the Italian vintages myself, and bought largely whenever I could.”), what does “materially” mean?
    A. exemption from punishment or loss
    B. be contingent upon (something that is elided)
    C. with respect to material aspects
    D. precisely and clearly expressed or readily observable; leaving nothing to implication
11. As used in the story (“I had told them that I should not return until the morning, and had given them explicit orders not to stir from the house.”), what does “explicit” mean?
    A. wear off or die down
    B. to flow in drops
    C. by good fortune
    D. precisely and clearly expressed or readily observable; leaving nothing to implication
12. As used in the story (“I said to him—"My dear Fortunato, you are luckily met.”), what does “luckily” mean?
    A. by good fortune
    B. grows
    C. express the need or desire for; ask for
    D. approached and spoken to

Part II: Short answer

1. Explain how revenge and pride develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.
2. Explain how deception develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.
3. Explain how the burden of the past develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.

Part III: Essay

Choose one of the story's central concerns (revenge and pride, deception, the burden of the past) and argue how the ending reframes it.

Answer key

Answer key: 1. A (A thousand injuries and then an insult); 2. D (With the promise of a rare cask of Amontillado); 3. A (A jester's motley costume with a cap and bells); 4. C (No one attacks me with impunity); 5. D (Fifty years); 6. B (to flow in drops); 7. C (express the need or desire for; ask for); 8. A (to flow in drops); 9. B (express the need or desire for; ask for); 10. C (with respect to material aspects); 11. D (precisely and clearly expressed or readily observable; leaving nothing to implication); 12. A (by good fortune)

Essay assignments

Essay: Revenge and pride

Middle School (600 words; AP: see unit standards): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Cask of Amontillado teaches about revenge and pride. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Edgar Allan Poe develops revenge and pride in The Cask of Amontillado. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Edgar Allan Poe develops revenge and pride across The Cask of Amontillado. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; AP: see unit standards): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Cask of Amontillado (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of revenge and pride. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of revenge and pride in The Cask of Amontillado. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Edgar Allan Poe's choices in The Cask of Amontillado (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of revenge and pride, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Cask of Amontillado's treatment of revenge and pride in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on revenge and pride in The Cask of Amontillado that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on revenge and pride in The Cask of Amontillado. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about revenge and pride in The Cask of Amontillado, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on revenge and pride in The Cask of Amontillado, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Deception

Middle School (600 words; AP: see unit standards): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Cask of Amontillado teaches about deception. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Edgar Allan Poe develops deception in The Cask of Amontillado. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Edgar Allan Poe develops deception across The Cask of Amontillado. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; AP: see unit standards): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Cask of Amontillado (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of deception. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of deception in The Cask of Amontillado. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Edgar Allan Poe's choices in The Cask of Amontillado (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of deception, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Cask of Amontillado's treatment of deception in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on deception in The Cask of Amontillado that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on deception in The Cask of Amontillado. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about deception in The Cask of Amontillado, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on deception in The Cask of Amontillado, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: The burden of the past

Middle School (600 words; AP: see unit standards): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Cask of Amontillado teaches about the burden of the past. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Edgar Allan Poe develops the burden of the past in The Cask of Amontillado. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Edgar Allan Poe develops the burden of the past across The Cask of Amontillado. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; AP: see unit standards): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Cask of Amontillado (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of the burden of the past. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of the burden of the past in The Cask of Amontillado. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Edgar Allan Poe's choices in The Cask of Amontillado (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of the burden of the past, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Cask of Amontillado's treatment of the burden of the past in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on the burden of the past in The Cask of Amontillado that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on the burden of the past in The Cask of Amontillado. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about the burden of the past in The Cask of Amontillado, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on the burden of the past in The Cask of Amontillado, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Original Liber et Libri curriculum. Quotations from the public-domain text. Vocabulary definitions are modern and contextual (curated; based on Princeton WordNet 3.0). Word histories appear only where verified (Online Etymology Dictionary, 2026-10-20); other words are student look-ups. AP and Cambridge entries are our own summaries with links, not College Board or Cambridge text; ICC-WC and LeL IDs are Liber et Libri labels. Included with every curriculum purchase and with Classroom Pro.